

Assignment 1 Part 2 Heritage Sites: A Comparison of Defensive Heritage and Urban
Development

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Architectural Conservation Philosophy and Ethics ARCH 4200

September 25th, 2025

Throughout history, settlements have had a strong tendency to form around military stronghold and fortifications. These military holdings would provide economic and safety benefits to its surrounding area, while also projecting the power and the control of the governing entity. In this document The Halifax Citadel National Historic Site in Canada and UNESCO designated Old and New Towns of Edinburgh, specifically the Edinburgh Castle in Scotland will be compared as military heritage sites that lead to surrounding urbanization and growth. At first glance these fortresses can seem quite similar, although this essay will bring to light both the similarities while highlighting the many stark contrasts. The Halifax Citadel is a classic example of colonial era British strategy, the star shaped fort constructed in the 19th century was established to protect one of their most important naval bases and the subsequent British subjects living there. The base was an impressive military engineering achievement both in design and strategic placement, especially in North America. This contrasts well compared to The Old and New Towns of Edinburgh with its organically evolved urban area, centered around the even older Edinburgh Castle. Often used by Scottish Royals, this castle was not only an important military defense for the city but also even for its country. Within the ancient capital of Scotland this Castle has a long and storied history both militarily and politically. While the Citadel was a planned, purpose-built imperial instrument for controlling a young, developing settlement made explicitly made for siege warfare. Despite significant differences in terms of geopolitical and chronological situations, these sites powerfully show their military prowess and how that greatly impacted the cities that sprawled around them. While both The Halifax Citadel National Historic Site and The Old and New Towns of Edinburgh show an enduring historical relationship between military power and urban growth, their comparison shows a crucial distinction. The Citadel represents a successful, though ultimately short-lived, model of imperial defense driving

colonial urban planning. Compared to Edinburgh Castle and city, which exemplifies the organic and enduring urban evolution seen more in old European settlements, resulting in distinct heritage values, character-defining elements, and conservation challenges that speak to their different historical trajectories and roles.

The Halifax Citadel was completed in 1856 as a state-of-the-art anti-siege star-shaped fortress built to protect the ever-strategic Halifax port that had become one of four principal naval stations in the British Empire¹. It was the fourth and final fortification on the hill overlooking Halifax Harbor, it was both a feat of civil engineering and was a testament to the British colonial organization also seen in the planned geometric urban expansion that followed. Having existed and grown since the mid-18th century with the surrounding city, the fort played a part in many of the Great Britain's North American incursions. Although never seeing direct conflict the fort provided important support and port protection for the British until in 1906, when the Canadian military assumed control of all Halifax defenses. The site then played a major role in both World Wars, being used as a detention camp during World War I, and Halifax headquarters for anti-aircraft defenses during World War II. Eventually, in 1956 the fort's active military involvement ceased and it became a national historic site and has since been restored for public visitation¹. In stark contrast stands the Old and New Towns of Edinburgh, although the military encampment of Edinburgh Castle is similarly situated upon a central hill, the surrounding urban development is quite different. Unlike Halifax, the pre-planned colonial outpost, Edinburgh was a bustling medieval capital and home to many Scottish Royals including

¹ "Halifax Citadel National Historic Site of Canada," Parks Canada - Directory of Federal Heritage Designations, accessed September 23, 2025, <https://www.canada.ca/en/parks-canada/places/historic-sites/halifax-citadel/index.html>.

kings and queens after it became the Scotland's chief royal castle in the Middle Ages². The castle was not only a military garrison but a royal residence, a seat of government, and a symbol of national Scottish identity. Also in contrast, Edinburgh and its castle were directly involved in a long list of conflicts, seeing many sieges and swapping ownership to invading British armies on multiple different occasions in the medieval era. This history and importance resulted in organic urban sprawl over hundreds of years, leading to storied unique development of The Old and New Towns of Edinburgh in direct contrast with the pre-planned nature of the colonial Halifax.

These two different sites remain in stark contrast when concerning heritage designations and values. The Halifax Citadel's designation as a National Historic Site of Canada is based on it being an outstanding example of colonial era British military engineering and its significance to Canada's role within the British Empire. Its value is specific and technical; it's during a particular phase of military history, and a tangible piece of colonial defense strategy. The heritage values identified are primarily architectural and military, focusing on the physical fortification itself¹. While having some cultural intangible heritage with reenactments and an ongoing connection to the rest of Halifax and the Canadian and British military history, it is not entangled with the national importance and history of its country as much as The Old and New Towns of Edinburgh. For this expansive heritage combined with the unique urban development Edinburgh was designated a UNESCO World Heritage site for its "outstanding universal value" as a city³. The designation is not just for the castle, but for the Old Town's medieval plan and the

¹ "Halifax Citadel National Historic Site of Canada," Parks Canada

² Johnson, Ben. "Edinburgh Castle." Historic UK. Accessed September 23, 2025. <https://www.historic-uk.com/HistoryMagazine/DestinationsUK/EdinburghCastle/>

³ "Old and New Towns of Edinburgh," UNESCO World Heritage Centre, accessed Sep. 11, 2025, <https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/728/>.

New Town's Georgian grid, a testament of evolving urban sprawl and planning. The heritage values encompass not only military history but also medieval urbanism, Georgian architecture, and the broader social and cultural history of a capital city³. The site's value includes the castle's military and cultural role, the Old Town's organic high-density urban form, and the New Town's planned grid. The site's heritage value is in the very progression from one to the other, making it a living museum of urban evolution. Compared to The Halifax Citadel's physical and relative static value, tied to a specific era of planned British colonialization.

This distinction is further emphasized by the key character-defining elements of each site. The Halifax Citadel's elements are exclusively military based with glacis, historic buildings, bastions, earthworks, open ground, pathways, and positioning all being crucial features¹. These elements were all designed to be part of a single, cohesive defensive system with the Halifax port. The character-defining elements of The Old and New Towns of Edinburgh are far more varied and connected to its own living urban development. While the castle is central, the Old Town's defining elements are the high-density buildings, with narrow alleys that branch off the Royal Mile³. The Old town's cobblestone streets and intricate stone details of its historic buildings define an organic medieval sprawl. While The New Town's defining elements include the contrastingly spacious streets and squares with elegant stone architecture that reflects the Enlightenment era³. Grand townhouses and open green space signal a profound change, showing the urban evolution that led to the highest-level designation a heritage site can get.

Lastly, the conservation challenges facing both sites are fundamentally different due to their contrasting nature and scale. For the Halifax Citadel, the primary challenges include

³ "Old and New Towns of Edinburgh," UNESCO World Heritage Centre

structural and material maintenance, with masonry and earthwork fortifications in the harsh coastal climate. The site needs to combat freeze-thaw cycles and erosion, while maintaining the ability to serve as a modest tourist attraction. This major challenge can be potentially aided by mitigation strategies including specialized heritage masonry repair, careful landscape management, and the use of modern monitoring technology to gain structural knowledge without physically altering the historic structures. Edinburgh's conservation challenges once again are in contrast with potential problems in balancing being a tourist destination and a modern large city. The sheer volume of visitors puts more pressure on its historic streets, buildings, and infrastructure. With the scale of these challenges, potential solutions will have to match the complexity and scale of the city. Therefore, mitigation efforts should be concentrated on the structural and material maintenance like the Halifax Citadel while taking into account modern needs. For example, investing in public transport that is less invasive and destructive to the environment instead of simply adding lanes for further inefficient vehicle use. These strategies should especially be used in the historic sections in The Old Town and other susceptible locations.

In conclusion, while both The Halifax Citadel and The Old and New Towns of Edinburgh powerfully demonstrate the historical relationship between military power and urban growth, their comparison reveals a stark contrast. The Halifax Citadel is an example of a planned colonial defense that drove planned urban development, resulting in a site tied to its static historic heritage value. Edinburgh in contrast, is a testament to the organic urban growth in a storied and cultural capital city, resulting in a complex urban landscape with multi-faceted heritage values.

These differing historical trajectories are reflected in their defining elements, their reasons for heritage designation, and the unique conservation challenges they face today.

Appendix A: Heritage Site Images



Figure 1⁴: 4. Alamy. Aerial, The Citadel NHS, Halifax, Nova Scotia. n.d. Alamy Stock Photo, accessed Sep. 11, 2025, <https://www.alamy.com/aerial-the-citadel-nhs-halifax-nova-scotia-image239676557.html>.



Figure 2⁵: 5. "Edinburgh Castle," Discover Castles, accessed September 11, 2025, <https://www.discovercastles.com/edinburgh-castle.html>.

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